

That's why it's important to at least do the following basic goals and planning work, so you know what you're spending and saving for. (If you want more information, I've covered this entire process in more detail in my book *Unf*ck Your Finances*.)

1. GOALS

The first step is to work out your goals. Think about the next three or five years of your life. If you could summon your future self and ask them what your life was like, what would they tell you? Or rather, what would you like them to tell you? Remember we need to live in the real world (no lotto wins!) but think about what you'd genuinely love your life to look like. Be as specific as you possibly can. Write what you'd tell yourself or, if you're not a writer, draw it, mind-map it, video it. Use whatever medium works for you.

If your inner critic pipes up and tells you this isn't realistic, tell them to pipe down! If you're worried that what you're dreaming up won't necessarily be accepted by your peers or your friends, who cares? This isn't about them; it's about you.

Examples of the life you're designing might include travel, business, corporate success, family success, giving your kids the educational opportunities you had (or didn't have), after-tax income of \$75,000 per year, buying a house, owning a number of investment properties, being child-free, being the first in your family to complete a degree, receiving a passive income of \$25,000 per year, retiring at age 55 and earning \$50,000 a year, adopting, fostering, having no debt, making a sea change or a tree change, earning your income in such a way that you could live anywhere in the world, building enough assets that in ten years' time you could drop to part-time work for as long as you want, taking a three-month sabbatical, heading off on a cruise in retirement once a year, rebuilding from a relationship breakdown, owning investments worth \$1 million or starting a not-for-profit.

The important thing is that your goals are tangible, and they excite you. If not, throw them out and start again.